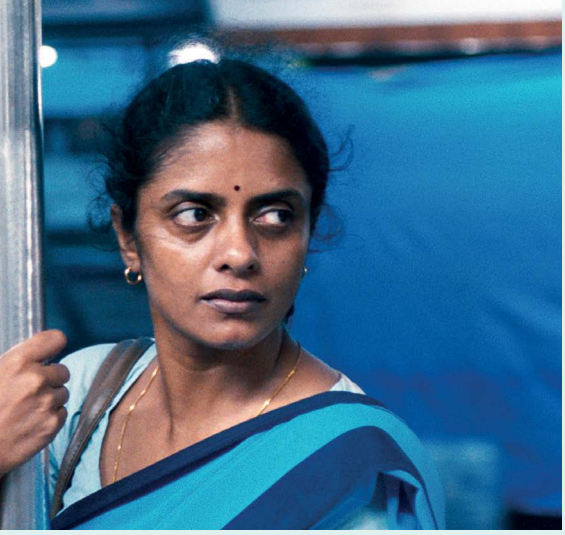


ing for her deceased husband. Her caretaker is melancholic too, missing her lover at sea. Payal's last short at FTII was one of 12 student films–and the only one from India–chosen for the Cinefondation category at the Cannes Film Festival

»THE LAST MANGO BEFORE THE MONSOON *(2017)*

Winner of the International Critics' Prize at the 61st International Short Film Festival Oberhausen, one of meccas for the short format

»AND WHAT IS THE SUMMER SAYING *(2015)*

Intending to make a short doc following a bee hunter, Payal ends up using voices featuring anecdotes and secrets from Kondwal villagers in Maharashtra to put together a dreamy landscape of rural life

»WATERMELON, FISH AND HALF GHOST *(2014)*

"They followed a routine in order to remember they are alive." In her first short, Payal shows her fondness for poetry, hushed voices and forlorn lovers, aspects that appear in her later works too

"IN PAYAL, I FIND AN ORIGINAL ARTIST, ONE WHO WANTS TO BE ABLE TO EXPRESS AND FIND HER OWN LANGUAGE. **HER WORK IS AS INTIMATE AS THAT OF A MINIATURE PAINTING ARTIST"**

–Shivendra Singh Dungarpur, ***Filmmaker***

outside Mumbai. Kapadia's exposure to cinema began early, watching works of documentarians like Anand Patwardhan, watching her mother edit work for video artworks and attending film festivals like the Mumbai International Film Festival (MIFF), known for its documentary, shorts and animation films, and Experimenta. It was while watching a lot of shorts from students of the Film & Television Institute of India here that she began thinking of applying to the esteemed institute in Pune. "There was a romanticism to the place," she says, "I remember thinking that this seems like a place where they are really trying things."

LEARNING THE HARD WAY

On her first attempt in 2007, Kapadia didn't make it to the editing course. Instead, she studied mass communication at Sophia College and began assisting filmmaker Shivendra Singh Dungarpur and later worked with video artist Tejal Shah. "I remember she used to get the work done, her big artistic bent," says Dungarpur of her. "She had what others didn't think, an amazing interpretation." In a moment of life coming full circle, Dungarpur, as artistic director of this year's Mumbai Film Festival, programmed *All We Imagine...* as the opening film. "In Payal," he says, "I find truly the emergence of an original artist, one who wants to be able to express and find her own language. Her work is almost as intimate as that of a miniature painting artist. In *All We Imagine...* she's painting the landscape of not only the human mind in Mumbai but of existentialism."

But Kapadia hadn't forgotten FTII. After five years of working, Kapadia felt she needed a "structure" before she embarked on her own journey as a filmmaker. "I didn't see myself growing after a point, I wasn't independent enough to say I could do it on my own," she says. This time, in 2012, she got into the direction batch. Kapadia spent five years at the institute, making shorts and doing projects on filmmakers like Portugal's Miguel Gomes and Thailand's Apichatpong Weerasethakul. She'd also be a part of the protests against the appointment of Gajendra Chauhan as FTII chairman. FTII was transformative for both Kapadia and Das, who was a year senior. "I owe FTII everything," says Kapadia. "It was a very important time and space to meet people." Adds Das, "The liberty we had to experiment both with our thoughts as well as our cinematic practices led us to constantly challenge our own preconceived ideas."

These days, Kapadia admits to being addicted to reading Letterboxd reviews of her film. "They are wild... I also mope wondering why they didn't get it," she says. "I just want people to like it... the film is you." Kapadia is now eager to get back to doing what she derives pleasure doing daily—writing—and has an idea brewing for another film set in Mumbai, though it's still "very vague". What's certain is that Kapadia's eye will observe, reflect and arrive at narratives that will irk if not challenge the status quo. And they'll be profound and beautiful while doing so. "For anybody who thinks about the world they live in, it's difficult not to respond to it," says Kapadia. "I can't help but respond to the zeitgeist of the country. We'll all be living under a rock if we don't." Kapadia refuses to, and Indian cinema is the better for it. ■